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Cosmopolitanism and the Devil in Malawi

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ABSTRACT *The article contributes to recent attempts to provide historically and ethnographically nuanced accounts of cosmopolitanism. A central argument in the article revolves around the notion of situated cosmopolitanism. While cosmopolitanisms must be envisaged in the plural, common to these diverse cultural projects is an uneasy relation to the home that imposes itself on the subject. Pentecostal Christians in an impoverished township in Malawi consider this-worldly realities as one, ruled by the Devil. Their cosmopolitan vision transcends, therefore, social and spatial boundaries, but it gains its force from their particular existential predicament of impoverishment. The article shows in detail how the Pentecostal belief in the second birth establishes a specific form of cosmopolitan relatedness. It entails a deterritorialized mode of belonging which undermines, among others, the rural–urban distinction.*

KEYWORDS *Pentecostalism, migration, urbanization, Malawi*

Since the early 1990s, Chinsapo township in Lilongwe, Malawi's capital, has been receiving unprecedented numbers of newcomers from the countryside and the capital's congested older townships. While most migrants continue to maintain close ties to their rural areas of origin, one group of newcomers displays a particularly cavalier attitude towards the rural–urban distinction. Pentecostal Christians, moving between rural and urban areas like other migrants, regard this-worldly realities as one, unaffected by the level of urbanization. They consider 'the world down here' (*dziko lapansi pano* in Chichewa) to extend from the poorest townships to the most affluent suburbs, from the most deprived villages to the greenest estates. It is a world ruled by the Devil (*mdyerekezi* or *mdyabulosi*), also known as Satan (*satana*), a world united by its common denominator – the Devil's incessant effort to introduce sin (*tchimo*) into people's lives. Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo

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township survey the signs of sinful acts with a growing certitude about the distinction that really matters – the one between this world and the world above, 'in heaven with the Lord' (*kumwamba kwa Ambuye*).

Like other members of imagined religious diasporas, Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo appear to be engaged in a complex process of home-making (cf. ter Haar 1998; van Dijk 1997; Werbner 2002). In this article, I want to explore Pentecostals' home-making by drawing upon recent insights into cosmopolitanism as an alternative vision of home. Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo, determined to emphasize the universality of both their predicament and their religious practice, would seem to be cosmopolitans, if a cosmopolitan is the one who 'refuses to think of himself (*sic*) as *defined* by his location or his ancestry or his citizenship or his language' (Waldron 1995:95; emphasis original). The aim of this article is to strike a note of caution, however. Cosmopolitanism must be historicized, its different forms situated in politico-economic conditions. Such an approach is necessary, if only to challenge a trend in sociological theorizing to monopolize – and essentialize – cosmopolitanism as a phenomenon of a particular type of society (see e.g. Beck 2000). The need is to apprehend cosmopolitanisms in the plural. Here, ethnographic and historical analyses come as invitations 'to think outside the box of European intellectual history' (Pollock *et al.* 2000:586; see also Friedman 2002; Nyers 2003; White 2002).¹

I ground my approach by examining, first, a recent innovative analysis of cosmopolitanism in Africa, James Ferguson's (1999) study of the changing fortunes of the Copperbelt towns in Zambia, Malawi's neighbour. Ferguson's interest is to understand variable commitments to imagined places *within* the same social context of Zambian towns. His interest arises from the need to counter the persistent dualistic models which situate African urban dwellers in the distinct realms of 'tradition' and 'modernity', 'village' and 'town', and so on. Instead, 'localism' and 'cosmopolitanism' emerge as different styles in the urban context, sharing a certain sense of a displaced disposition. Both presuppose migration, localism as a commitment to a 'home' in the village, cosmopolitanism as a willingness to neglect or ignore rural kin (Ferguson 1999:211–212). Cosmopolitanism, as a style in opposition to localism, does not require experiences of globetrotting travel nor high social standing; only the rejection of the 'local' by means of cultivating a conspicuously 'urban' style is at issue (Ferguson 1999:289). The reassuring tone of localism, professing rural belonging despite urban existence, is confronted by cosmopolitanism as, in Ferguson's words, 'a series of slaps in the face' (1999:212). While cosmopolitanism disconnects as localism connects, both entail their particular structure of social relations.

If Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo township appear to embrace some aspects of cosmopolitanism as defined by Ferguson, it is because they firmly reject any available local site as their ultimate home. For Ferguson, the historicity of cosmopolitanism is closely associated with migrants' changing capacities to live independently of their rural allies. On the Copperbelt, the decline of the copper industry has made rural areas more important economically, thereby giving localism an advantage over cosmopolitanism (Ferguson 1999: 230–233). I describe, by contrast, an urban situation in which cosmopolitanism and rural allegiances are compatible. Urbanization in Malawi has always been on a more modest scale than in Zambia, propelled by petty trade rather than by industrialization.² In an important sense, the cosmopolitanism of Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo township is even more radical than the one Ferguson has described. It involves them in cultivating *both* urban and rural social networks without a distinction. Confined to the rural–urban dualism, cosmopolitans in Zambian Copperbelt towns subscribe to a spatialized notion of lifestyles. Preoccupied with the omnipresence of the Devil, Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo navigate this-wordly realities as a social and spiritual rather than a spatialized landscape.

It may be objected that to regard Pentecostalism as one example of cosmopolitanism is to abuse concepts. Cosmopolitanism, many would argue, is characterized not only by the fact of cultural hybridity but also by the awareness and celebration of this hybridity as the condition of one's existence. Pentecostalism, as an apparent prototype for Protestant fundamentalism, would seem to allow little occasion for such celebration. Pentecostal Christians are staunch believers in the superiority of their particular vision and eschew influences from other systems of belief. The contrast between Pentecostalism and cosmopolitanism appears less obvious, however, if it is accepted that relativism is not a necessary feature of the cosmopolitan outlook on the world. A comparative study of different cosmopolitanisms may well inquire into what cosmopolitans consider universal and absolute in different settings. Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo township, who by no means stand here as ahistorical examples of abstract Pentecostalism, are proud of the ethnic and cultural diversity that this transnational movement encompasses. Some aspects of that diversity are condemned, while others prove the universality of Pentecostalism by indicating precisely how much difference it can accommodate.

Although different practices and preoccupations can come under the category of cosmopolitanism, and thereby reveal the need to historicize it, it is important to be clear about the condition which minimally characterizes all

cosmopolitanism. This is the fact that the cosmopolitan imagination emerges when there is unease or uncertainty about the 'home' that most immediately imposes itself upon the subject. The condition calls for relational thinking in analysis, something that Ferguson's notion has achieved in its definition of 'cosmopolitanism' and 'localism' as features of the same life-world. Without relational thinking, without an appreciation of what *compels* cosmopolitans to adopt their particular ways of engaging with the world, the analyst may be too quick to emphasize cosmopolitanism as a playful construction of alternative styles. Relational thinking erases the unfortunate habit of thought to privilege entities, such as 'a plurality of contrasting cultures' in Hannerz's (1996:103) understanding of the cosmopolitan's life-world (cf. Robbins 1998: 254). When entities are privileged, the cosmopolitan is situated outside a relational field and imagined to be engaged in the playful hybridity of what Rushdie calls 'the migrant condition' (1991:393). Migrants and the members of diasporic communities engage, in this perspective, in diverse (and often unrestrained) projects of cultural construction which travelling, information technology and the mass media afford.

The perils of this perspective become more clear if the corollary of cosmopolitanism – home – is theorized a bit further. A recent anthropological discussion of the notion of 'home', for example, elevates movement to a universal condition of home-making in the contemporary world (see Rapport & Dawson 1998). The discussion is sophisticated enough to take issue with sociologists over an influential notion of 'the homeless mind' in modern societies (see Berger *et al.* 1974), particularly over its evolutionary assumptions and whether 'homelessness' is a necessary consequence of movement. These anthropologists suggest that 'home' often retains its salience in a world of motion. 'Home' is constructed as a notion and a set of practices, rather than as a place, against these conditions: 'Exile, emigration, banishment, labour migrancy, tourism, urbanization and counter-urbanization are the central motifs of modern culture, while being rootless, displaced between worlds, living between a lost past and a fluid present, are perhaps the most fitting metaphors for the journeying, modern consciousness' (Rapport & Dawson 1998:23).

These anthropologists make a salutary intervention by taking the notion of 'home' as problematic. Cosmopolitanism presupposes, as Ferguson suggests, a notion of 'home', and yet, as he goes on to contend, 'cosmopolitans ... cannot and will not be "at home" at home' (1999:212). The cosmopolitan predicament is, *pace* Rapport and Dawson, less the spectre of homelessness, 'displacement between worlds', than the discomfort of the existing home. In

other words, cosmopolitans do not enter, in a constructivist fashion, a world of motion in order to create order out of chaos, as autonomous subjects in a passive environment (cf. Englund 2002a). Rather, cosmopolitans, like other people, are inextricably *situated* in particular homes whose presence, if only imagined, constitutes the ongoing compulsion to engage in the cosmopolitan projects of transcending them.³ The predicament of Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo township shows that the necessary presence of a home does not presuppose the primacy of a 'place' in social life. In this case, home is the virtually unbearable existential condition one is thrust into as a human being.

Situated Cosmopolitanism

Cosmopolitanism among Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo township revolves around their belief that the presence of the Devil constitutes the human condition. Their perspective is at variance with that of a secular ethnographer who seeks to identify the specific historical conditions of their belief (cf. Brodwin 2003). Although the perspectives will remain incompatible, it is of some consequence how the economic and political context of beliefs and practices is evoked in analysis. This context is not given here as an 'explanation' of the conditions where the evidence of the Devil's presence seems to be so compelling. Such causality would regard conditions as external to symbolic action, as if beliefs and practices were secondary constructions out of objective conditions. The analytical challenge is, rather, a phenomenological one – to understand intentional and embodied subjects as historically situated *within* specific conditions of action (cf. Csordas 1994; Kapferer 2002). Later in this article, the possibility of a deterministic explanation is further undermined by a consideration of the contrasting social and economic conditions that appear to give rise to Pentecostalism in contemporary Africa. It is those economic and social conditions that constitute the 'home' in which cosmopolitans pursue their variable projects.

Among migrants in Chinsapo township, uncertainty permeates their lived experience under the current political and economic conditions. Malawi belongs to the poorest nations in the world, with over 60 per cent of the population classified by the United Nations as 'poor', out of whom 30 per cent are unable to meet their basic food requirements (UNDP 2001). Many migrants make their living as petty traders, whose meagre income and savings are quickly dissipated by crises such as illnesses, leaving the afflicted destitute or highly dependent on others. Security is seldom more actual among those who are formally employed, most of whom work as night-watchmen, domestic servants

and low-ranking civil servants such as drivers and clerks. Salaries are very low, trade unions weak, and employers often have no qualms about dismissing those who demand better pay.

Despite the vicissitudes of urban life in Malawi, Chinsapo's impoverished township continues to grow. Its annual growth rate is likely to be higher than the 7 or 9 per cent estimated for the city as a whole (Kalipeni 1999:73). In the late 1990s the township had about 30,000 residents. This growth has to be understood in the context of national politics. The general elections in 1994 ushered Malawi in the new era of multiparty politics, a period of 'freedom' (*ufulu*) which the country's poor attempt to manipulate to their own advantage. One example are migrants in Chinsapo township who, as squatters occupying an 'unplanned area' in the eyes of the city and state authorities, would have been too intimidated before the political transition to settle there in such large numbers. The new ruling party United Democratic Front (UDF), which won the elections in both 1994 and 1999, also intensified neoliberal reforms in the economy. The removal of subsidies on agricultural inputs jeopardized smallholder farming, insufficiently countered by the new government's populist hand-outs of seeds and fertilizer, known as Starter Pack Schemes. The UDF has also promoted small-scale enterprises as a development strategy. In the absence of widespread credit facilities, such promotion has been largely rhetorical. It has, however, been welcomed by the country's poor, who have flocked to high-density settlements in the main cities of Lilongwe, Blantyre and Mzuzu. Their enterprises are often on a very small scale indeed, with manufacture clearly less prominent than trade in imported commodities. Their plight indicates, in point of fact, a nation-wide economic crisis which has been made worse by unprecedented inflation and the devaluation of the national currency.⁴

Chinsapo township has among its residents migrants from all the districts of Malawi, and according to my sample of 300 households in 1996-97, about 50 per cent of migrants cultivated land in their rural areas of origin during the current season (Englund 2002c).⁵ No district had more than 16 per cent of the total number of migrants in the township. The proportion of migrants from the surrounding Lilongwe district was only seven per cent. About 90 per cent of migrants expected to 'return' (*kubwerera*) to their village of origin sooner or later. In this respect, the urban context in Malawi is very different from the one which Ferguson (1999) has described for Zambia. The very modest level of industrialization in Malawi has kept its people as smallholders in villages, as agricultural labourers on tobacco estates, or as labour migrants

elsewhere in southern Africa. Urban growth in the 1990s has been a consequence of both diminished opportunities to emigrate and the new government's rhetoric about private entrepreneurship. As such, Malawians do not share Zambians' experience of a relatively long urban history and their concomitant popular debates which Ferguson has analyzed with the concepts of 'localism' and 'cosmopolitanism'. The village is an obvious and integral aspect of most migrants' lives in Malawi, although the ultimate 'return' is often achieved only at death through burial in the village of origin. As the case of Pentecostal Christians demonstrates, cosmopolitanism, in this rural-urban continuum, is something else than a reaction against localism.

The diverse origins of Chinsapo's residents have given rise to a thriving and complex scene of religious life in the township. Virtually every Christian denomination found in Malawi is represented in the township, while two large mosques, 'traditional' healers' numerous practices and the all-male *gule wamkulu* (*nyau*) secret society ensure that Christianity belongs to a field of religious and spiritual pluralism. As in the rest of the world, Pentecostalism appears to be the fastest growing form of Christianity in the township.⁶ Chinsapo's Pentecostals claim diverse ethnic and regional identities but generally ignore them in their congregational life. Most members of Pentecostal congregations are middle-aged women and young women and men. In 1999, 15 different Pentecostal churches had active congregational life in Chinsapo. Seven of them were branches of mission churches from abroad, while eight of them had been established in Malawi (Englund 2003). Many Pentecostal Christians belong to congregations outside the township, making the total number of the Pentecostal churches represented in the township higher than 15. Pentecostal Christians themselves emphasize the provisional nature of the boundaries between different churches, and they freely visit each others' churches. Different emphases in doctrine and practice do occasion comment, but usually require personal conflicts to make congregations split (Englund 2001).⁷ Such conflicts often draw upon the most unifying aspect of the Pentecostal doctrine – the belief in the omnipresence of the Devil. The sources of conflicts are, as such, to be found in the machinations by the Devil.

The Devil

Dziko la pansi landida ine
Ndaona kuti kuno si kwathu
Koma kuli nkondo ndi udani
Tsono ndaona kuti ndibwerere

This world has let me down
 I can see here is not our home
 There is war and hatred
 I can see I must go back

(Chorus)

*Ndibwerera oh ndibwerera**Ndibwerera inu mayi kumwamba**Dziko la pansi landida ine**Ndaona kuti kuno si kwathu**Koma kuli njala komanso nsanje**Tsono ndaona kuti ndibwerere*

(Chorus)

*Dziko la pansi landida ine**Ndaona kuti kuno si kwathu**Koma kuli imfa komanso matenda**Tsono ndaona kuti ndibwerere*

(Chorus)

(Chorus)

I go back oh I go back

I go back mother to heaven

This world has let me down

I can see here is not our home

There is hunger and jealousy

I can see I must go back

(Chorus)

This world has let me down

I can see here is not our home

There is death and disease

I can see I must go back

(Chorus)

This song, composed by a Pentecostal pastor in Chinsapo township, is a lucid exposition of central aspects of the Pentecostal life-world. It lists war, hatred, hunger, jealousy, death and disease as the defining features of the 'world down here', pushing the person to look for the real home elsewhere. The origin of these troubles in this world is the Devil, whom Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo refer to as 'the chief of this world' (*mfumu wa dziko la pansi*). The mere fact that people occupy this world makes them vulnerable to the Devil's machinations. This is also the reason why, in the Born-Again cosmology, the first birth in flesh has to be complemented by the second birth which is achieved through baptism in the Holy Spirit. In fact, the behaviour of the child during the first birth already indicates the need for the second birth. Every child cries when it is born, Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo say, because it is received by the Devil as soon as it has emerged from the womb. Standing between people and God, the Devil thereafter attempts to make its evil rule appear as the natural state of affairs.

The central role played by the Devil makes it a figure on a par with God in popular Christianities (cf. Taussig 1980; Cervantes 1994; Meyer 1999). Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo township are well versed in the Biblical accounts of how the Devil came into being, sometimes giving those accounts a personal and localized flavour. Among God's first creations were angels (*angelo*), a group of which, led by an angel known as Lucifer, revolted against God and was sent to 'the world down here'. Adam and Eve subsequently disappointed God even further by conceding to Satanic temptations, thereby

condemning humanity to the sinners' condition. However, God's grace (*chisomo cha Mulungu*) made it possible to receive salvation (*chipulumutso*) by believing in Jesus Christ as his only son, alone able to lead human beings to the Kingdom of God (*ufumu wa Mulungu*). As a result, spiritual warfare (*nkhondo ya uzimu*) rages in the 'world down here' until the present, with only the Born-Again (*obadwa mwatsopano*) being entitled to benefit from the eventual second coming of Jesus Christ (*kubwera kachiwiri kwa Yesu*). In the meantime, the spirits (*mizimu*) of the Born-Again sleep in peace after death, while the spirits of those who have yielded to the Devil are restless after death, returning to haunt their living relatives.

Spiritual warfare is a recurrent theme in Pentecostal sermons and everyday parlance in Chinsapo township. It is evoked to urge Pentecostal Christians to devote time to praying and partly accounts for the passion with which sermons and prayers are delivered. The challenge is not only to defeat the Devil but to ensure that God even hears the prayers. Demonic spirits (*ziwanda*) execute the Devil's commands, trying their best to prevent prayers from reaching their destination. Some Pentecostal Christians offer elaborate typologies for demonic spirits. For instance, certain Bible schools and colleges, where pastors receive their training, have a module called Miracle Ministry which introduces students to the hierarchical structure of the demonic society. Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo – pastors and lay members alike – commonly make an analogy between the hierarchy among Malawian political leaders and that of the demonic spirits. Just as there are President, Cabinet Ministers and Members of Parliament, so too are there demonic spirits at different levels of their hierarchy. One pastor in Chinsapo township explained to me that the Devil has its representatives at the international, national, regional, municipal, village and street levels. Accordingly, demonic spirits can also be differentiated along these levels, and every Born-Again wages spiritual warfare at a level appropriate to his or her maturity and understanding. Pastors, my interlocutor continued, struggle with demonic spirits which are 'number four if not five from the top'. Jesus fought directly with the Devil – the creature highest in the hideous hierarchy.

The more elaborate a person's diabolology, the more likely it is to contain elements which others dispute. Yet it is important to understand that Pentecostal Christians' preoccupation with the Devil by no means alienates them from the rest of Chinsapo's residents. The Devil is, in fact, the one spiritual entity that seems to afford some common ground within the bewildering religious pluralism in the township. 'Spiritual insecurity' (Ashforth 1998) may

be a corollary of the proliferation of interpretations for misfortune and success, but the Devil is the central figure which organizes those interpretations and counter-interpretations as mutually intelligible arguments. Interpretive authorities – pastors and priests of various denominations, imams, healers – may talk *against* each other but seldom *past* each other. Moreover, the existence of the Devil appears to be taken for granted to the extent that few township dwellers have patience to reflect on the question why omnipotent God allows evil in the world. Not only is there a plausible explanation in the form of God's disappointment with certain angels; more importantly, the omnipresence of the Devil – experienced in the troubles listed in the above-mentioned song – is overwhelming enough to make the issue of protection and salvation much more urgent. In the midst of spiritual warfare the surest way to face defeat is by questioning the potency of the belligerent powers.

The immediate outcome of spiritual warfare is uncertain, and the advances made by the Born-Again are often provisional. The most scandalous discovery is to realize that the Devil's subjects have infiltrated into a Pentecostal congregation. They are exposed when the congregation's fierce praying, dancing and singing have made the Holy Spirit descend. Persons who are under demonic influence find the presence of the Holy Spirit too much to bear, start crying, sweat profusely, often fall down on the ground or try to run away. At this point those with expert knowledge about 'exorcizing evil spirits' (*kutulutsa ziwanda*) subject the demonic person to a violently intensive treatment in which they lay their hands on him or her and command in loud voices the demons to leave the person 'in the name of Jesus' (*mu dzina la Yesu*). Pentecostal Christians refer to such incidents when they talk about the need for constant vigilance against the Devil – not even a Pentecostal church can be taken for granted as a haven in the Devil's world. In practice, of course, such incidents serve to prove the formidable power of Pentecostal worship. If they did *not* happen, if the apparently unexpected revelations of demonic presence were not forthcoming, the congregation could reasonably begin to doubt the efficacy of its prayers. A somewhat similar dilemma haunts pastors who, as the leaders of congregations, are expected to ease their Christians' afflictions. If the laying-on of hands and praying do not result in healing, doubts may arise about the pastor's credentials as a Born-Again.

'Appearances deceive' (*maonekedwe amapusitsa*) is a popular saying in Chichewa and describes well Pentecostal Christians' predicament in Chinsapo township. Hypocrisy (*chinyengo*) invites passionate condemnation, and sermons often lament how easily worship and church-going become a habit

(*chizolowezi*), with no real engagement in the predicament of 'the world down here'. Pastors and others who lead sermons ridicule men in smart suits and women in beautiful dresses who, with a Bible in hand, crowd the pathways of the township on Sundays, only to be found later in sinful activities, such as beer-drinking and adultery. The concern with misleading appearances resonates with a widespread belief in witches' (*afiti*) capacities to change (*ku-sanduka*) their human appearances into animal ones. Witches are the most feared agents of demonic powers, and dreams about snakes, or encounters with hyenas, are the most typical instances of Satanic interventions for Pentecostal and non-Pentecostal residents alike in Chinsapo. The fundamental issue, Pentecostal Christians admit, is that the Devil is 'clever' (*wochenjera*), ceaselessly attempting to entice people into sin. The Devil has the capacity to see what is in God's hand before the person has received it and does everything to prevent the good from happening.

The concern with deceptive appearances forces Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo to lay great weight on practice. It is how the person conducts his or her Christian life that matters. This emphasis partly accounts for the fact that most Pentecostal churches in Chinsapo require little Bible study as a pre-condition for baptism, and for the fact that everyone in the congregation is allowed to pray aloud, interspersing Pentecostal services with moments of sheer cacophony. The imperative of Christian practice extends to every facet of life, and every Born-Again is expected to pray even when he or she is alone. Wrongdoings, in particular, demand instant prayers which admit mistakes and request God's forgiveness. Pentecostal Christians do not, therefore, regard themselves as infallible; nor do they defer admitting their mistakes to an occasion of formal confession. There is, however, an important distinction between Pentecostal Christians and 'sinners' (*anthu a tchimo*). The former make mistakes because of ignorance, while the latter commit sins as results of deliberate planning. Sins, in this sense, are intentional acts, committed under demonic influence.

Blood and Water

The question of intentionality reveals a central aspect of Pentecostal Christians' notion of the subject. There are two kinds of subjects, they say: 'children of this world' (*ana a dziko la pansi*) and 'children of God' (*ana a Mulungu*). The only common characteristic between these two groups of people is the fact that no one is an autonomous individual acting out of innate wickedness or goodness. It may be recalled that, according to Pentecostal Christians in

Chinsapo township, the new-born child is grabbed by the Devil, at once thrust into spiritual warfare in which individuals owe their qualities to specific spiritual forces. Each subject is, in other words, a composite of these forces which mould the individual into an acting and intentional subject. As mentioned, appearances are thought to be deceptive, and it is only through observing a person's conduct over a period of time that his or her constitutive qualities can be established. Moreover, because persons are no more than composites of spiritual forces, Pentecostal Christians deplore all attempts to elevate human beings into objects of worship. Catholics, in particular, come under criticism for their alleged habit of 'worshipping idols' (*kupembedza mafano*), such as the figure of the Virgin Mary.

In a world of deceptive appearances, trouble and demonic machinations, Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo township are attracted to their faith by the promise of 'security' (*chitetezo*) rather than by the prosperity gospel, another important theme in certain Pentecostal and charismatic contexts (see e.g. Maxwell 1998; Droogers 2001). I return to this contrast later in the article. Security is achieved by becoming a subject constituted by the Holy Spirit, which will thereafter steer the person's life. Healers' protective medicine against witches, for example, becomes redundant, and the Born-Again Christian is able to walk anywhere at any time without fear. Certain words, such as the chanting of the name of Jesus, can activate the Holy Spirit, and crucial to the second birth is the person's explicit acceptance of his or her sins and the willingness to admit Jesus as his or her saviour. Others may precipitate the transformation by preaching and praying for the person, but baptism in the Holy Spirit is not thought to be a human achievement. As one Pentecostal Christian in Chinsapo explained to me: 'We are taught by the Spirit, we are not taught by human reason' (*timaphunzitsidwa ndi mzimu, sitiphunzitsidwa ndi nzeru za munthu*).

Ritual practice enacts important aspects of the Pentecostal transformation. The most obvious one is baptism through total immersion in water. In a sense, it enacts the death and resurrection of Christ, related here to a person's own experience as his or her deliverance from sin. Submerged by water, the person 'dies' and leaves this-worldly vices, emerging as a Born-Again. In a pattern common to the Christian tradition, water is analogous to blood, and immersion effectively enacts the person's purification by the blood of Jesus. Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo keenly refer to passages in the Bible to prove the correspondence between blood and water, such as Hebrews 10:22 and 1 John 5:5–13. What is effected is corporeal unity among all Born-Again

Christians, because the blood that Jesus shed runs in their veins, and they are 'protected by the blood of Jesus' (*otetezedwa ndi mwazi wa Yesu*). Individual traits are hardly noticed, let alone valued, and Born-Again Christians are one in Jesus; 'we are in one body with Jesus Christ' (*tili m'thupi limodzi ndi Yesu Khristu*). Spiritual unity is, therefore, experienced as corporeal unity, the separation between the spirit and the body taking place only at death.

When Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo township emphasize this-wordly suffering, they adopt not only the resurrection of Christ but also his agony as a basis of relatedness. The blood that Jesus shed as his sacrifice for sins protects against demonic machinations. In this sense, the apparent emphasis in baptism on resurrection and the promise of redemption (cf. Werbner 1997: 320) is only one side of the second birth. The suffering of Christ is also the suffering of Christians in this world, no less than his resurrection is their resurrection. Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo township experience the agony which Jesus must have felt in the daily flow of the township's godless life, in the omnipresence of the Devil, in disease and in death.

The second birth establishes relatedness, indeed its own kind of blood relatedness. Purification replaces one blood with another as it delivers the person from the condition of sinfulness. Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo see no reason to understand the process as directed specifically against their own 'ancestral' blood, and thereby their own cultural tradition (cf. Meyer 1998), because at issue is the deliverance from the *universal* human condition. The relatedness thus established permits Born-Again Christians to address one another as 'brothers' and 'sisters', and great solicitude awaits even those who visit, as apparent strangers, a Pentecostal congregation which they do not know. The importance of blood as substance of kinship resonates with the ideas of procreation in Malawian traditions (see Englund 1999:143), but it is also crucial to appreciate how the distinction between 'biological' and 'social' kinship may not be recognized (see Carsten 2000). Just as the substance of blood needs to be enhanced by other means, such as the consumption of maize, in the reproduction of persons (Englund 1999:144), so too is the blood relatedness of Born-Again Christians verified through practice. In other words, the bodily substance of blood is in neither case thought to stand as a sufficient and immutable source of kinship, as a 'fact' of biology. At the same time, however, blood draws our attention to the importance of corporeal *experience* in kinship.

For Pentecostal Christians who find themselves forced to live amidst this-worldly suffering and immorality, the relatedness established through the

blood of Jesus is the closest approximation of 'home' before the coming of the Kingdom of God. Their predicament as cosmopolitans revolves around the way in which the home they identify with is constantly challenged or undermined by the home which constitutes their immediate daily environment. Their relatedness through blood does not carry, however, connotations of the imagined 'home' merely as a family; as in the ideologies of modern nationalism, blood can also unite persons as a nation or an ethnic group (see Linke 1999). Christianity has, moreover, from its earliest years given a special emphasis to the idea of the *ethnos* (Peel 2000:281). As such, it has often played a major role in the emergence and maintenance of modern nationalism (see Hastings 1997).

The analogy between nationalism, ethnicity and the predicament of Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo must be treated with caution, because their sense of nationhood and ethnicity appears to transcend conventional boundaries. Pentecostal Christians are a group whose presence, like that of refugees and diasporic communities, unsettles the 'national order of things' (cf. Malkki 1995). They spread across national boundaries, never at home in any of the units which those boundaries demarcate. The cosmopolitanism of Pentecostal Christians becomes clear when they are compared further with some groups of refugees and diasporic migrants. Whereas displacement and migration sometimes presuppose, and enhance, a sense of belonging to a place elsewhere, often equated with a nation-state, Pentecostal Christians are committed to a radically deterritorialized view of their ultimate home. No Jerusalem on earth animates their imagination. The evidence of earthly imperfection is too overwhelming to permit, for them, a holy enclave in this world.

Contrasting Pentecostalisms, Contrasting Cosmopolitanisms

Seen from the outside, Pentecostal congregations in Chinsapo township appear as close-knit groups, tied together not only by their regular Sunday services but also by a whole range of formal and informal collective activities. During the week, intercessions and overnight prayers bring Pentecostal Christians together in private houses, and the prayer groups for youths and women have their own meetings at least once a week. Pentecostal Christians are also expected to take part in excursions, known as crusades, during which the gospel (*uthengo wabwino*; 'the good news') is spread more widely through songs and preaching. Congregations also act as groups when their members fall ill or have funerals. During such crises, the congregation gives money or other material and practical help to the afflicted and keeps them company. It

can be an impressive sight when a congregation walks as one group in the township after its Sunday service to see the sick or the bereaved. In addition to these expressions of group solidarity, however, Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo have diverse connections which only partially overlap with those of their congregations. For example, Christians from all denominations participate in popular prayer sessions, known as fellowships, which allow outsiders to acquaint themselves with Pentecostal ways of worship without joining Pentecostal churches. Pentecostal Christians also cultivate relationships with members of other Pentecostal congregations than their own. Such friendship also often entails material assistance during life-crises, and Pentecostal friends from different congregations may, for example, accompany one another to a mountain to pray during a period of fasting.

Just as Pentecostal Christians' social networks extend to other Pentecostal congregations than their own, so too are their contacts with persons who do not share their form of Christianity more frequent and multifarious than the stress on a new life-style would suggest. For Pentecostal and non-Pentecostal township dwellers alike, disowning a relative is particularly rare, a punishment to be unleashed only under extreme circumstances, such as when the evidence of the relative's involvement in witchcraft is considered to be indisputable. In practice, township dwellers live in the constant uncertainty about the true identity of those who purposefully maintain evil in the world. Under such uncertainty, Pentecostal Christians are certain only about their protection against evil. Although their non-Pentecostal relatives may often hear about the need to be Born-Again, no Pentecostal Christian I met in Chinsapo wanted to cut their links to them. No less than other township dwellers, Pentecostal Christians also regard land in the village of origin as essential and move between the town and the village with ease. They inevitably remain close to their relatives in the village and display little desire to distance themselves from a specifically 'rural' way of life.

These observations provide a standpoint to address significant differences between Pentecostal dispositions in contemporary Africa. Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo differ, for example, from urban Pentecostals in Ghana who, according to Meyer, seek to 'close themselves off from kin' (1998:199). As Meyer makes clear, this aspiration is rarely fulfilled in practice, but significant here is the emphatic denial of those kin relations that antedate the second birth. The contrast to Chinsapo's Pentecostals becomes even sharper when it is observed that the middle-class Ghanaians studied by Meyer use the conventional Christian emphasis on the nuclear family as a barrier against relatives'

claims on their wealth. The life-world of Chinsapo's Pentecostals is very different. When few township dwellers, whether Born-Again or not, can count on permanent urbanization, access to land and other resources in rural areas remains indispensable. While middle-class Pentecostals might condemn some of the consequent practices as backsliding, the impoverished Pentecostals of Chinsapo are more likely to experience them as evidence of Satanic machinations.

Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo condemn only specific practices associated with 'traditional' or 'rural' domains. Yet even when they seem to subscribe to non-Pentecostal practices – such as burying the dead in their villages of origin – they do so in a critical relation to existing notions. A widespread belief in the region maintains that the deceased's spirit must be placated by a proper funeral ceremony, an important feature of which is its staging 'at home', usually the village of origin. Pentecostal Christians deny, however, that the spirits of those who died as Born-Again are potentially harmful. Burial in the village is not, therefore, a simple assertion of belonging to the rural home. Amid customary expressions of grief, Pentecostal funerals are joyous occasions, celebrations of the fact that the deceased is united with God and only temporarily separated from the living Born-Again. More crucial than the location of the burial is the desire that persons from the deceased's own church conduct prayers and hymns during the funeral. This can be difficult to arrange, if the deceased has joined a Pentecostal church which is not represented in his or her area of origin. If the congregation is able to raise enough funds, the pastor and a few members of the laity join the funeral in the village. In other cases, Pentecostal churches in Chinsapo advise their laity to obtain a letter from their pastors before the corpse is taken to the village. This letter confirms the deceased's Pentecostal identity and requests assistance from any Pentecostal church or pastor in the area in conducting the funeral. Belonging to a specific Pentecostal church is, once again, less important than identity as a Born-Again Pentecostal Christian *tout court*.

Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo do not define their faith as an 'urban' or 'modern' phenomenon, if only because some Pentecostal churches have long roots in rural areas after early missionary work in the 1940s and establish branches in town through migrants.⁸ Their passionate condemnation of 'healers' (*asing'anga*), many of whom draw upon Christian paraphernalia and discourse, concerns the sources of healing powers, not 'tradition' or ancestral ways as such. Rather than representing a continuing tradition, *asing'anga* are some of the many ways in which the Devil incessantly attempts to reinvent

itself in order to keep people under its influence. When Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo elaborate on their rejection of *asing'anga*, they point out that 'European' medicine (*mankhwala achizungu*) is based on research in laboratories, while local healers' secretiveness about the origin of their medicine suggests Satanic guidance.⁹ The fact that, for Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo, ancestral traditions are not at issue is revealed by their responses to the question of how people were healed before the arrival of 'European' medicine and Christianity. They say that 'ancestors' rules were strong' (*miyambo ya makolo inali yamphamvu*), preventing surrender to the Satanic temptations that are now all too irresistible. In those days people died of old age or witchcraft, less often because of disease.¹⁰ Before the arrival of Christianity people 'feared ancestors' (*ankaopa makolo*) just as some now 'fear God' (*amaopa Mulungu*). Even at the national level in Malawi, Pentecostal leaders have appealed to ancestral ways of life when the nation has pursued reconciliation and peace. During the run-up to the 1999 elections, Pentecostal pastors were able to make the presidential candidates share a meal as an ancestral way of reconciliation (Englund 2000:595–597).

The security gospel among Chinsapo's Pentecostals is another indication that their Pentecostalism no less than their cosmopolitanism is a historically specific phenomenon. As mentioned, the security gospel differs from the prosperity gospel which promises material wealth to the righteous. It is common to hear Pentecostal pastors in Chinsapo criticizing the rich for being less assiduous than the poor in prayers and other forms of worship.¹¹ It is, in this view, precisely their wealth that makes the rich complacent and ultimately destroys their security. By contrast, in Zambia, where Gifford reports the prosperity gospel to be 'so common, so axiomatic, so pervasive' (2001:65), the association of deliverance with prosperity can support an effort to spatialize and racialize the Devil's domain. This effort is particularly evident among those elite Pentecostal students who condemn anything 'African' as backward, immoral and insidious (see Simpson 1998, 2003). They resemble the cosmopolitans of the Copperbelt who, according to Ferguson (1999), condemn the 'local'.

The Pentecostal elite and migrants on the Copperbelt are less radical in their cosmopolitanism than Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo township. Cosmopolitanism among Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo revolves around the need to be on one's guard wherever one goes in this world. There is no difference between town and the country, poor areas and rich areas, as far as the presence of the Devil is concerned – these Pentecostal Christians engage

with a deterritorialized world. Deterritorialization is here both translocal and transnational, although, in Chinsapo township, the extent to which Pentecostal Christians have personal links to their spiritual brothers and sisters in foreign countries varies greatly. However, awareness about Pentecostalism as a global phenomenon, if only through religious tracts, audio-tapes and videos, is widespread and clearly contributes to the self-confidence with which Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo express their faith (Englund 2001, 2003). The transnational networks which support Pentecostalism enable them to imagine the conflict between this world and the Born-Again as a universal rather than as a local, Malawian or African predicament.

Conclusion

The perspective of this article, ultimately incompatible with Pentecostal Christians' own and yet offered to illuminate it, has sought to unravel specific conditions for Pentecostal Christians' cosmopolitanism, the polity in their *cosmopolitanism*. Impoverishment defines the politico-economic circumstances of their existence as migrants in Chinsapo township, and they never have to look far for evidence that the Devil rules this world. Lives are precarious, among children no less than among adults; a business enterprise can face a sudden collapse when illness, funeral or witchcraft depletes its capital; alcohol and marijuana are widely consumed among township dwellers, disrupting the life in the township with brawls, domestic violence and adultery. Even among those who still have great expectations for the capacities of the 'democratic' regime to change their lot, inflation and several neoliberal reforms to 'open' the market force them to qualify their enthusiasm. Pentecostalism in Chinsapo is a mode of being-in-the-world which makes, however, poverty seem only one aspect of the troubled human condition. Wealthy suburbs have, in this perspective, their own share of misfortune and immorality. Some Pentecostal congregations in Chinsapo want, for example, to send their own missionaries to Europe, convinced that the extent of worldliness has reached alarming proportions there (see Englund 2001, 2003).

If Pentecostal Christians appear as cosmopolitans in Chinsapo township, the question becomes who are their ideological opponents – 'localists' in Ferguson's (1999) analysis? As this article has tried to make clear, Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo do not qualify as cosmopolitans because they regard other township dwellers as parochial localists. Even among those migrants in the township who do not contemplate an eventual return to the village of origin, the village (*mudzi*) is an acceptable synonym for 'home', and they often

lament their own difficulties to return. In other words, localism is not a recognized 'style' which would have cosmopolitanism as its opposite, because virtually everyone sees the village as the ultimate home. Pentecostal Christians may be the only social group which professes open dissatisfaction with this notion of home, again less because of aversion to the rural domain than because of an existential predicament that makes this-worldly realities look the same. Pentecostal Christians in Chinsapo want to transcend their immediate this-worldly home in order to find a home in a deterritorialized mode of belonging. They move and yet remain emplaced; however far they migrate, however many are their moves, they remain just as far from and near to their ultimate home, the Kingdom of God.

The advantage of Ferguson's contribution over the notions of cosmopolitanism mentioned in the beginning of this article hinges on its capacity to define cosmopolitanism in relational and historical terms. On the Copperbelt, cosmopolitanism was, broadly speaking, at its height during the 'boom' years of the 1950s and 1960s, while localism has more recently become common as urban dwellers have found it necessary to recreate rural alliances (Ferguson 1999:230–233). The urban areas in Malawi have never witnessed comparable periods of boom, and therefore localism has also been less remarkable there as a style than on the Copperbelt. As this article has shown, however, cosmopolitanism remains a useful analytical tool despite such historical differences. To be sure, the historicity of cosmopolitanism must be understood to give rise to different *forms* of cosmopolitanism, and it would be a mistake to take Ferguson's ethnographic case as a paradigm for all cosmopolitanism. Clearly, cosmopolitanism may or may not be in tension with localism, or, as in the case of township dwellers in Chinsapo, it may not require localism as its ideological opposite at all. The empirical variations of both cosmopolitanism and Pentecostalism in contemporary Africa are likely to be great. For example, in contrast to the middle-class Pentecostals discussed above, non-Pentecostal elite cosmopolitans in African towns may be keen to cultivate social ties in villages, subscribing to rural and regional autochthony as a basis of political power (see e.g. Nyamnjoh & Rowlands 1998). Whatever its empirical form, cosmopolitanism should not be understood as free-wheeling, ill-defined in-betweenness which has characterized its content in much sociological usage. Historicized cosmopolitanism is situated in specific politico-economic circumstances and trajectories.

Rather than assuming a particular style or discourse as the invariable ideological opposite of cosmopolitanism, this article has stressed the importance

of 'home' in any definition of cosmopolitanism. It may appear counter-intuitive to regard home as the ground on which cosmopolitan projects are built. Yet imagined and enacted homes are precisely the historical circumstances in which cosmopolitans are compelled to pursue their projects. Homes may be spatialized – Africa as 'second-class' against the rest of the world (cf. Ferguson 1999, 2002) – or they may be deterritorialized as counter-homes in the cosmopolitan imagination. Pentecostal cosmopolitans in Chinsapo township contemplate sending missionaries to Europe, convinced that the conditions of earthly homes there are essentially the same as in Africa. The historical understandings of 'home' are as variable as are the cosmopolitan projects which try to transcend them. Crucial is the *situatedness* of the cosmopolitan predicament. Few cosmopolitans can afford the playful construction of social worlds implied in some metropolitan imaginings. Cosmopolitans are embedded in specific politico-economic conditions as historical subjects.

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Notes

1. Christianity has, of course, constituted one of the earliest global designs in world history. For unconventional readings of the histories of cosmopolitanisms, including Kant's influential ideas, see McCarthy (1999) and Mignolo (2000).
2. Five per cent of Malawi's population lived in urban areas at independence in 1964, while the 1998 population census indicated that still only 14 per cent lived in urban areas (Kalipeni 1999:61; National Statistical Office 1998:10; Potts 1985: 184). In neighbouring Zambia, by contrast, the population that lived in urban areas increased from 20 to 40 per cent of the total population between independence in 1964 and 1980 (Hansen 1997:5). Half of Zambia's population is estimated to live in urban areas at present.
3. For a stimulating discussion of how the notion of 'situated' cosmopolitanism does not need to be tied to the confining metaphor of locality, see Robbins (1998). Following especially Casey (1993, 1996), I have elsewhere discussed in more detail the sense in which emplacement is an existential rather than a spatial condition (see Englund 2002a).
4. For recent studies of the political economy of Malawi's democracy, see Englund (2002b).
5. I have conducted fieldwork in the township in 1996–97, 1999, 2000 and 2001–2003, in total for over two years. The language of fieldwork has been Chichewa, the national language of Malawi and the lingua franca of the township.

6. An estimated 74 million Pentecostal and neo-Pentecostal Christians represented six per cent of the world's Christian population in 1970. By 1996 the figure was 480 million or 27 per cent, more than the combined numbers of Protestants and Anglicans (see Barrett 1996:25).
7. For recent syntheses of the available scholarship on Pentecostalism, stressing its capacity to transcend social and political boundaries, see Droogers (2001) and Martin (2002).
8. Assemblies of God from the United States was the first Pentecostal church to establish itself in Malawi in the 1940s. For historical perspectives on Pentecostalism in southern Africa, see e.g. Maxwell (2002) and Schoffeleers (2002).
9. Pentecostals' condemnation of *asing'anga* obscures considerable differences among these healers. While some healers are self-conscious followers of 'ancestrals customs' (*miyambo ya makolo*), others mimic biomedical practices in their clinics. Some even claim to be Born-Again Christians, although they are not allowed to belong to Pentecostal churches. Whatever the spiritual outlook, the most successful healers usually command extensive knowledge of medical botany (see Morris 1996).
10. The disease that most clearly defines 'the present' (*masiku ano*) for many Malawians is AIDS. Since the early 1990s, the HIV sero-prevalence rate has been around 25 per cent of the adult population, one of the highest in the world (UNDP 2001: 41). Under-nourishment also wreaks havoc among the populace, and malaria is a fatal disease especially among children.
11. For example: 'Do you know that it is not many among the rich who are touched by God? They see no reason to pray ... 'They think that "oh, should I pray? What will I benefit since I have everything?"' (*Kodi mukudzizwa kuti anthu olemera si ambiri amene ndi okhudzidwa ndi Mulungu? Amaona kuti palibe chifukwa choti apemphere ... Amaganiza kuti 'oh, ndipemphere? Ndipindula chiyani, popeza zonse ndili nazo?*).

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